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19 WAYS TO OVERCOME SKEPTICISM

1. *HISTORY.* Years in business, years your product has been on the market, etc.

2. *STATISTICS.* Numbers of customers, users. Dollars saved. Number of customers satisfied.

3. *TESTIMONIALS FROM USERS.* In most cases, the most powerful marketing tool of all is the good things that our customers say about us. "Real people" testimonials are essential.

4. *TESTIMONIALS FROM EXPERTS.*

5. *TESTIMONIALS FROM CELEBRITIES.*

6. *DEMONSTRATIONS.* If your product or service can be demonstrated, it should be.

7. *BEFORE/AFTER PICTURES* and other photographs. Photographs are generally accepted as "proof."

8. *CREDENTIALS.* An individual's academic credits, accomplishments, awards. A company's memberships and affiliations.

9. *PUBLICITY.* Reprints of articles from magazines and newspapers give your product, service or business "news value." There is a feeling that equates being worth writing about to have general merit.

10. *CELEBRITY SPOKESPERSON.* Celebrities do work in advertising.

11. *COMPARISONS.* Like a "taste test."

12. *GUARANTEES AND WARRANTIES.* If you cannot back up your product or service with a clear, straightforward, strong guarantee,

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find something better to sell. People who fool around with conditional guarantees" and worry about being taken advantage of by their customers need to look in the mirror and at the true value of what they are selling.

13. ***EXCEPTIONAL CUSTOMER SERVICE.*** Example: a 24-hour toll free help line that customers can call.

14. ***ACCESSIBILITY.*** Don't hide in a P.O. Box. Have a street address, a known location, and a phone number manned by your own people, not an answering service.

15. ***EXCEPTIONAL VALUE/IRRESISTIBLE OFFER***. Simply, when something is desirable enough, people will buy even in spite of skepticism!

16. ***THE PERSONAL APPROACH.*** Lee Iaccoca has been an extraordinarily effective spokesperson for his own company. This is very common in mail-order: Lillian Vernon, Elizabeth Adler, Roger Horchow, all names and people well known to their companies' customers.

17. ***DAMAGING ADMISSION.*** Every product has some disadvantage. Consider honestly addressing this issue.

18. ***ANSWER QUESTIONS & OBJECTIONS.***

19. ***EXCESS..."PREPONDERANCE OF PROOF."*** Over-use as many of the above 18 strategies as you can. What will seem like excess to you may still not be enough for your customer.